conservative mindset, as well as – at least in some places – the continued dominance of informal centres of power in the institutions of the state and in the civil society. The end result is a polarised society, with frustrated segments of the population, and a poor record of the state in relation to the rule of law, which could pave the way to an authoritarian future. This is especially dangerous when faced with crisis situations like those experienced in the recent past (financial, migration and health) or present (the war in Ukraine, energy and food security issues, as well as the return of migrants). This requires much more than the annual exercise of the EU Rule of Law Reports, especially since these papers do not get beneath the normative surface. In fact, no serious attempt to tackle the deficiencies to the rule of law in Eastern Europe can avoid addressing or at least acknowledging and taking into account the region's totalitarian past and its consequences.

This book has also been arguing that – while strongly rejecting views that are in opposition with the basic tenets of liberal democracy – the roots of populism in Europe have something to do with the question of what exactly liberal democracy and above all the European identity are and what European values actually are. The conference on the future of Europe and the emergence of the European Commission's portfolio on the European way of life attest that this is far more than an academic question – even if, or all the more, because neither of them seem to have produced tangible results. In that respect, developments in Central and Eastern Europe as described have a significance and pose questions that are relevant far beyond the region. One certainly cannot be content with the current Polish and Hungarian answer to these questions (little else has come from other countries in the region, so perhaps there is some untapped potential), but neither has the West nor Europe as a whole produced a real answer – yet. We are rather seeing a helpless convergence of social-democrats, liberals and people's parties around a loose, ill-defined and colour-less set of values and rights, blind about historic and cultural context. But such often aggressive post-modern secularism that in one stroke excludes conservative sections of the society is not a viable answer neither.

In fact, it seems that we are more distant from answers to the questions about European values than we were in the early post-war period, when the foundations of the European institutions (Council of Europe and the EU)